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## From the editor-in-chief

Every time it comes around, I find myself astonished by the football World Cup. By its size, by its popularity and by how it becomes centrestage to the entire world once every four years. The football World Cup is without doubt the biggest sports event in the world. This is because football is our planet's biggest sport. According to an official survey by soccer's ruling body FIFA carried out in its 207 member countries, there are said to be 270 million people involved in football across the world, as players, coaches, referees, officials.

The 2006 World Cup held in Germany was watched by a cumulative television audience of 26.29 billion, with 376 television channels showing matches live in 214 countries, more than the 192 countries of the United Nations. Due to the event, FIFA raised over \$2 billion in marketing revenues while Germany's tourism earnings went up by \$400 million.

This year the World Cup is even more special because for the first time ever, it is going to a continent it has never been to. Unlike Europe or South America where football has drawn all its champions from, or even Asia with its financial clout, Africa has a chequered history. In politics it is a continent of conflict. In football, only one country, Cameroon, has ever made it to the second round of a World Cup.

But they don't call football the beautiful game for nothing. The decision to award the 2010 World Cup to South Africa is a bold one. Many believe that this will be a World Cup with a very distinct flavour, given South Africa's unique landscape and lively audience, regardless of security threats and the home team's struggles.

Our cover story this week is about the colour and the spectacle of the first football World Cup ever to be held in Africa. Deputy Editor Sharda Ugra writes about the event and whose fates it will decide. South African journalist Lungani Zama tells us about the excitement in his own country heading into the opening match on June 11 and also the best places to visit at the World Cup venues, tourist attractions and the special things that can only be found in South Africa. Some South African cities have a reputation for crime and our guide looks at the special measures put in place to ensure the safety and security of tourists attending the matches.

Plus we have selected the INDIA TODAY World XI of stars to watch out for, offered you the odds about who may win the \$30-million prize money and who may score the most goals in the event. We have also stuck our neck out with a list of predictions going into the second round, and let's say that list will be scrutinised closely in our office as the Cup progresses.

Even though India does not feature anywhere in the competition and is unlikely to do so (many believe in our lifetimes), the World Cup always sets us alight. Before we know it, we will be seeing murals being painted on walls across cities and names like Messi and Kaka being adopted by Indian households. So you may not be one of the lucky ones to be in South Africa for the World Cup but our package will give you a front row seat. Enjoy the action.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR JUNE 2006 COVER